seen the letter—deliberately leaked by the Americans—from Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee to President Bill Clinton justifying the nuclear tests in terms of the nuclear threat in our periphery. Vajpayee had made a direct reference to the distrust that existed between India and China, as well as to the material assistance that China had rendered to Pakistan in its nuclear weapons programme. The Indian Prime Minister held China as one of the parties responsible for the deteriorating security environment in South Asia. [14]

The Indian narrative ran contrary to the narrative that China was crafting. By 1998, the Chinese were assiduously cultivating the image of a benign Great Power that was helping the world by developing itself and acting responsibly in terms of peace and security in the global context. They wanted to erase memories of the early years when China was perceived as a threat in the region. The justification that India was now offering in support of its nuclear tests threatened to undo this effort and revive the notion of the 'China Threat'. The *Liberation Army Daily*, which is the mouthpiece of the Chinese Army, proclaimed that India was raising a hue and cry about the 'China Threat' theory to land China in a difficult position in its (India) efforts to seek hegemony in South Asia. [15] China was angry because it felt that its image was being impugned.

The Indian nuclear tests had also caught the Chinese by complete surprise for two reasons. First, they regarded themselves as having a sound understanding of India's leadership and foreign policy, and assumed that India lacked the political will to challenge the international community on the nuclear issue. Second, their experience at the NPT Review Conference and the CTBT negotiations had imbued them with a sense of confidence that they had closed ranks with the United States of America and that both shared the common objective of enforcing the global nuclear non-proliferation arrangements